



how to write cover letters

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Writing a cover letter can feel like a daunting task, especially if you're new to the job market. But don't worry! We're here to help.

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A well-crafted cover letter can make a huge difference in your job search. It's your chance to show employers who you are, highlighting your enthusiasm, skills, and fit for the role. In this article, you'll find all you need to know about writing a cover letter, from what to include to top tips for making your application stand out. Let's get started!

What is a cover letter?

A cover letter is a separate document that you submit along with your resume when applying for a job. Think of it as a personal introduction to the employer, where you get to explain why you're a great fit for the position. While your resume lists your qualifications and experiences, a cover letter gives you the chance to showcase your personality, enthusiasm, and communication skills.

Not all job applications ask for a cover letter, so you don't have to write one for every job you apply for. However, a cover letter can still help as it can offer additional insights into your qualifications and enthusiasm for the position, potentially influencing the employer's decision to consider you for an interview. But be sure to read the job description carefully, as some employers may explicitly state they do not require or accept cover letters.

When the job listing *does* specifically ask for a cover letter, it's important to include one.



What to include in a cover letter

A well-structured cover letter should include the following:

1. Contact information:

At the top of your cover letter, include your name, phone number, and email address. Make sure your email address and voicemail are professional and appropriate. You might consider creating a new email address specifically for job applications. Also include the date you wrote the cover letter and the employer's contact information.

2. Greeting:

Address the hiring manager by name if known. There is usually a contact name on the job description, but if you can't find someone to address, you can simply write "Dear Hiring Manager".

3. Introduction:

In the opening paragraph, introduce yourself and explain why you are writing. Mention the job you are applying for and where you found the job listing. This is important, as the company might be hiring for multiple roles at a time.

4. Body paragraphs:

A typical cover letter usually consists of three to four body paragraphs. In these paragraphs, you should address the selection criteria and highlight your relevant skills,

experiences, and achievements. Explain how these make you a great candidate for the job. Be specific and provide examples.

5. Conclusion:

Summarise your interest in the role and express your eagerness to discuss your application further. Thank the employer for their time and consideration.

6. Sign-off:

End with a professional sign-off, such as "Yours sincerely" or "Best regards," followed by your name.

How to write a cover letter

Now that you know the structure of a cover letter, let's jump into the steps to create one - including detailed information on what to include in each section.

Step 1: Research the company and role

Before you start writing, research the company and the specific role you're applying for. Understanding the company's values, culture and needs will help you tailor your cover letter to show that you've done your research and that you're a good fit. Some companies might even have instructions on their careers page outlining what they'd like applicants to include in a cover letter, so be sure to check their website just in case.

Step 2: Create a template

Start with a basic template that includes your contact information, a greeting and a structure for the body and conclusion. This will make it easier to customise your letter for each application. You could utilise AI generators such as ChatGPT for this, but make sure you always make edits to personalise it and make it sound like you before sending it to anyone.

Step 3: Write a strong opening paragraph

Capture the reader's attention with a compelling introduction. Mention the position you're applying for and how you found out about it. It can also be good to explain why you're excited about the position and why you believe it's a great fit for you, even if the role is slightly outside your demonstrated skills, experience or current location. This shows your genuine interest and enthusiasm.

Here is an example: *"I am excited to apply for the Retail Assistant position at XYZ Store, as advertised on your website. With a strong background in customer service and a passion for the retail industry, I am confident in my ability to contribute to your team."*

Step 4: Highlight your relevant skills and experiences

In the body of your cover letter, focus on your most relevant skills and experiences. Use specific examples to demonstrate how you've successfully used these skills in the past.

This is where you demonstrate why you're the ideal candidate for the position and address the selection criteria from the job ad. You could also try using the [STAR method](#) to explain these skills and accomplishments.

You could start this section off by saying something like: *'In my previous role as a sales associate at ABC Store, I developed a variety of skills that I believe will make me a valuable addition to your team,' then follow on with your most relevant skills that relate to the selection criteria.*

Step 5: Show enthusiasm for the role and company

Employers want to hire people who are excited about the job and the company. Explain why you're passionate about this specific opportunity and how you can contribute to the company's success. Showing the hiring manager that you understand the company's values, culture and goals, and how they align with your own, can set you apart from other candidates who may not have taken the time to learn about the organisation.

Here is an example of what you could say: *'I am particularly impressed by XYZ Store's commitment to customer satisfaction and would love the opportunity to bring my skills and enthusiasm to your team. I am confident that my experience and dedication to providing excellent customer service will contribute positively to XYZ Store's success.'*

Step 6: Conclude with a "call to action"

Wrap up your letter with a polite and confident closing. Express your eagerness to discuss your application in more detail and thank the employer for considering you.

As an example, you could say something like: *'Thank you for considering my application. I look forward to the opportunity to discuss how I can contribute to your team further.'*



Cover letter writing tips

Do's

Do personalise each cover letter:

Tailor each cover letter to the specific job and company. Mention the company's name and the role you're applying for to show that you've done your homework. You could also include keywords from the job description to help your application [get past the robots](#).

Do be concise:

Try to keep your cover letter to one page. Be clear and to the point, avoiding unnecessary information. If you're finding that your cover letter is a bit long, read over it and make sure you haven't repeated information. A two-page cover letter may be acceptable in some circumstances, particularly when a role requires you to demonstrate extensive experience or a variety of skills.

Do highlight your achievements:

Focus on your accomplishments and how they relate to the job you're applying for. Use quantifiable results to demonstrate your impact. If you don't have any previous work experience, you could focus on your achievements at school or other activities you were involved in (often called 'extra-curricular activities'), such as volunteering for school events, contributions within your sports team or helping the neighbours or family friends with chores or small jobs.

Do use a professional tone:

Maintain a professional tone throughout your cover letter. Avoid using slang or overly informal language. Some organisations might be a bit more casual than others, so you could also try to match the tone that the company has used in their job description.

Do proofread:

Carefully proofread your cover letter to catch any spelling or grammatical errors. A polished letter shows attention to detail and professionalism. It could be helpful to have someone else proofread it too, like a family member, friend, teacher or someone else you trust.

Do format and label your document appropriately:

Save your cover letter in a PDF or Word document format to ensure it's easily accessible and maintains its formatting across different devices. Some job ads may specify the preferred format, so be sure to follow those instructions if provided. Label the document clearly with your name and the position you're applying for, such as "John_Doe_Cover_Letter_Sales_Assistant.pdf". This makes it easy for hiring managers to identify and file your application.

Don't's

Don't re-use a generic template:

Avoid using a 'generic' cover letter for every application. While it's okay to use a template that you've used before, make sure you read through it and edit information about the company and role where necessary. Personalisation is key to making a strong impression!

Don't rely entirely on AI-generated content:

Avoid submitting a cover letter that has been entirely generated by AI without making any edits. It's important to personalise and refine the content to ensure it sounds like you and fits the specific job you're applying for.

Don't repeat your resume:

Your cover letter should complement, not duplicate, your resume. You can use your cover letter to expand on specific experiences and skills listed in your resume and explain how they relate to the job you're applying for.

Don't include irrelevant information:

Stick to the most relevant experiences and skills. Including unrelated information can make your cover letter seem unfocused and can distract the reader from your key strengths and qualifications. Stick to important details that directly showcase your suitability for the job.

Don't overuse 'buzzwords':

While it's important to use industry-specific language, overloading your cover letter with buzzwords can make it sound insincere. Words and phrases like "team player," "go-getter" and "passionate" are often overused and may not make a meaningful impact on employers. Instead, talk about real examples that show what you can do. This will make your cover letter sound more genuine and interesting.

Cover letter examples

To help you get started, we've created a couple of cover letter templates that you can use as a guide. These templates are designed to be ATS friendly, ensuring that your application gets through the initial screening process. Simply download the templates, customise them with your information, and you'll be on your way to crafting a stand-out cover letter!

[Cover letter template #1 - with work experience.docx](#)

[Cover letter template #2 - no work experience.docx](#)

Writing a cover letter may seem daunting, but with these tips and a bit of practice, you can create a great letter that showcases your strengths and sets you apart from other candidates.

Remember, your cover letter is your chance to make a good first impression, so take the time to craft a thoughtful and personalised letter for each job application. Good luck!

Get support

If you're aged 15 - 25 and want some advice on writing a cover letter, searching and applying for work, and everything in between, get free and confidential support from headspace Work and Study.

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Find your [nearest headspace centre here](#), or for online and telephone support, visit [ehespace](#).

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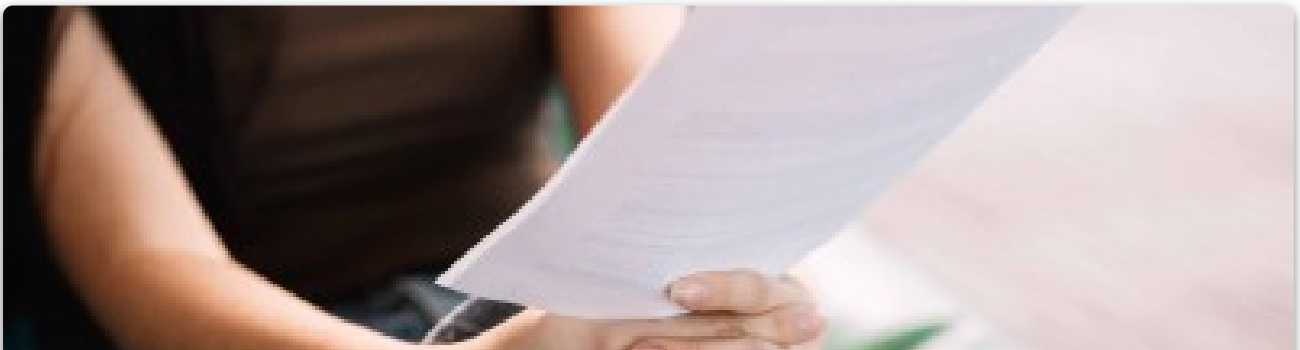
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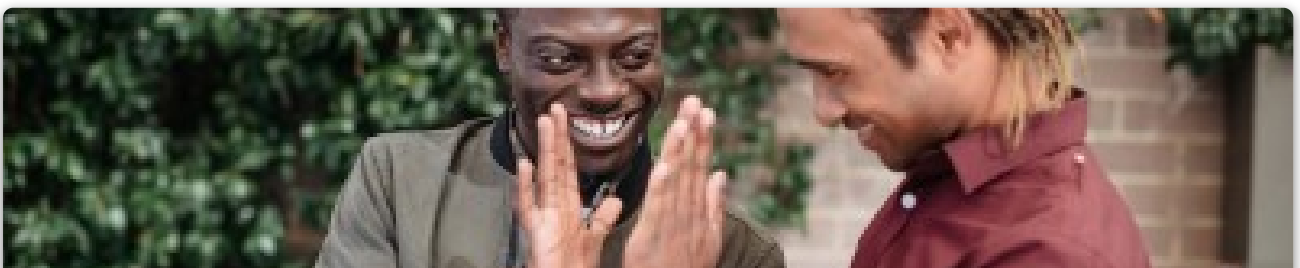


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